Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Joel

Joel 1:1

- This is the word of the LORD (literally The word of the Lord came): The Lord, not the human prophet, was the true source of these words.
- The name Joel means "the Lord [Yahweh] is God." Joel's father, Pethuel, is unknown outside of this verse.

Joel 1:1–2.17

The prophet Joel describes a severe locust plague that struck Judah and Jerusalem.

Joel 1:2

- Hear this: Joel called the people to pay close attention to the prophecy.
- elders: The prophet asked the community elders if anything like this had happened before. It had not. This disaster was unique in the history of God's people.

Joel 1:3

God's people would share their experiences with future generations. This way, their descendants could learn from the lessons they had gained (compare Deuteronomy 4:9; 6:20–25).

Joel 1:4

Judah faced a terrible locust plague. Some experts think the four types of locusts symbolize four ancient empires that conquered Israel. Others believe the words describe four stages of locust growth. The prophet probably used different terms to highlight the massive destruction caused by the relentless insects.

Joel 1:5

Wake up ... wail: The prophet wanted to alert the people to the seriousness of the locust plague.

Joel 1:7

The destructive power of locusts is well known in both ancient and modern times. These hungry insects feed on crops such as grains and vegetables. They also destroy fruit trees and vines, leaving the branches white and bare.

Joel 1:8

Wail like a virgin: Judah is like a young engaged woman whose marriage never happens because her husband dies.

Joel 1:9

The locust plague threatened the people of Judah with starvation. It stopped the daily animal sacrifices and grain and wine offerings at the temple in Jerusalem (compare Exodus 29:38–41; Numbers 28:2–8).

Joel 1:10

The locusts destroyed the three main staple crops of ancient Israel:

- grain
- grapes
- olive oil

Joel 1:12

The drought made the locust plague worse. Everything withered and dried up (see also Joel 1:19–20). Spiritually, the people's joy vanished with the fruit trees.

Joel 1:13–14

The priests were to guide everyone in public mourning ceremonies at the temple. Their actions should show genuine inner change (see Joel 2:13).

Joel 1:15

- The locust plague was not just a natural event. It was a sign that the day of the Lord was near. Starting with Amos in the 700s BC (Amos 5:18), prophets spoke of a future time when God would step into human history to judge the wicked and support the righteous.
- destruction from the Almighty: The Hebrew text emphasizes the similar sounds of the word destruction (shod) and the title the Almighty (shadday).

Joel 1:17

Plague and drought destroyed the food supply, leaving the barns with no stored grain.

Joel 1:18

The people of Judah struggled because of the famine. Even sheep and goats, which can survive on little food, cried out because they had nothing to eat.

Joel 1:19

To You, O LORD, I call: Joel responded to the plague with a sincere prayer. The people could only turn to the sovereign Lord of heaven and earth and ask for his goodness. He alone could change their desperate situation.

Joel 1:20

All creation suffers because of human sin (Genesis 3:17–18; 9:2; Romans 8:20–21). Even wild animals cry out to God. The Hebrew word translated "pant" is the same as in Psalm 42:1, where the deer "pants" for water. The animals, needing food and drink, show how the people of Judah and Jerusalem should seek their Lord (see Isaiah 1:3).

Joel 2:1

When attackers threatened an ancient city, the watchmen on the city wall would sound the alarm by blowing a trumpet. This trumpet was a ram's horn instrument called a shofar (see also Joel 2:15). The sound called all the defenders to fight the enemy.

Joel 2:1–11

Some scholars understand this section as a second description of the locust plague in chapter 1. But in chapter 1, the plague is described as a past event. In this section, the verb tenses seem to describe a future event.

For this reason, other scholars understand the passage as a warning of another locust plague that has not yet happened.

Still other commentators understand this passage as apocalyptic language (symbolic language about God's future judgment). In this view, the writer uses the imagery of a locust plague to describe an invading human army on the coming day of the Lord.

Joel 2:2

Some religious leaders taught the people of Jerusalem and Judah that the day of the Lord would bring blessings for God's people. Echoing the prophet Zephaniah (Zephaniah 1:15), Joel declared that it would actually be a day of darkness and gloom (see also Amos 5:18–20).

Joel 2:3

The destruction caused by the invading army would be like a fire that spreads quickly and destroys everything in its path. Before the attack, the land looked like the garden of Eden. After the attack, the land would be empty and ruined. This image reverses the hope described in Isaiah 51:3 and Ezekiel 36:35.

Joel 2:4–5

- Their appearance is like that of horses: The similarity between locusts and horses (see also Revelation 9:7) emphasizes the image of locusts as an army.
- With a sound like that of chariot: A swarm of locusts can make an extremely loud noise that is hard to endure.

Joel 2:6

Nations writhe in horror before them: Anticipating the invasion prepared the people for the call to repentance in Joel 2:12–14.

Joel 2:7–9

The locusts invaded both cities and farms, moving like a well-trained army. They scaled city walls and swarmed over the city. They found every way to enter, even climbing through windows like thieves.

Joel 2:10

The shaking of the earth and sky often signals a theophany, which is an appearance of God (see Exodus 19:16–19; Isaiah 13:13; Nahum 1:5–6). The darkening of the sun and moon represents divine judgment (Isaiah 13:9–11).

Joel 2:11

- The LORD raises His voice in the presence of His army: The coming destruction was not just nature or human actions, but an act of God.
- His camp is very large: God carried out this judgment.
- Who can endure it?: Without God's grace and mercy, no one can.

Joel 2:12

- This verse starts with declares the LORD a phrase often used for divine messages in the prophets. It is the only time it appears in Joel. This shows that the invitation came directly from God.
- return to Me with all your heart: The Lord urged his people to repent because judgment day was near. They still had a chance to avoid destruction by truly returning to the Lord their God.
- Unlike other prophets, Joel does not list the sins of Judah and Jerusalem. Perhaps they were so obvious that he did not need to mention them.

Joel 2:12–17

Joel urges the people to repent and rely on the mercy of their compassionate God.

Joel 2:13

- In the ancient world, people showed grief by tearing their clothes (Genesis 37:34; 2 Samuel 3:31; 2 Kings 19:1).
- rend your hearts: In Hebrew culture, the heart represents thought, faith, and will. God wanted people to repent inwardly, not just outwardly. This meant changing their mindset, priorities, and attitudes. They could only do this by returning to the Lord.
- For He is gracious and compassionate ... abounding in loving devotion: The people's only hope was in the Lord's merciful nature (see also Exodus 34:6–7; Numbers 14:18; Nehemiah 9:17; Psalms 86:15; 103:8; 145:8; Jonah 4:2). God wants to forgive and restore his people, not punish them.

Joel 2:14

Who knows?: Joel's simple question acknowledges God's complete control (see also Jonah 3:9). God does not have to restore us just because we perform certain rituals. Forgiveness comes only through divine grace, but Joel knew that God was willing to forgive (Joel 2:13).

Joel 2:15

Joel asked for a time of fasting and a serious meeting to seek God.

Joel 2:16

bridegroom ... and the bride: Newlyweds were exempt from most civic duties in ancient Israel (see Deuteronomy 24:5; Luke 14:20). However, in this emergency, everyone would be called to the temple to pray to God.

Joel 2:17

Spare Your people, O LORD: Gathered at the temple, the religious leaders and everyone else could only do one thing in their desperate situation. The religious leaders wanted the people to ask for God's mercy and compassion.

Joel 2:18

Since both people and land suffered from God's judgment, they would both receive his passionate compassion.

Joel 2:18–27

God promised to restore the material life of his people in the near future. He would refill their fields, orchards, vineyards, and flocks.

Joel 2:18–3.21

So far, the book of Joel has discussed God's judgment on Judah and Jerusalem. From now on, it talks about God's promise to restore them. If the people truly repented, God would respond with kindness.

Joel 2:19–20

grain, new wine, and oil: God would restore the land's produce. This would provide the elements needed for sacrifice and worship (see Joel 1:10, 13). God would also remove the invading armies from the north.

Joel 2:21–22

Do not be afraid: God's great deliverance would be full and complete.

Joel 2:23

autumn rains ... and spring rains: God would restore the regular rainfall pattern, reversing the drought (Joel 1:12, 20).

Joel 2:25

God promised to restore what the locusts destroyed (see Joel 1:4, 10, and Joel 1:4, 10).

Joel 2:26–27

You will praise the name of the LORD your God: God promised to restore your crops and food supply. This should lead the people of Judah and Jerusalem to praise and adore him. They should acknowledge that the Lord is among them and that he alone is God.

Joel 2:28–29

I will pour out My Spirit on all people: In Israel, the empowering gift of God's Spirit had previously been given only to select individuals such as:

- judges (Judges 3:10; 15:14),
- priests (2 Chronicles 24:20),
- kings (1 Samuel 10:10), and
- prophets (Isaiah 61:1).

A time was coming when the Holy Spirit would be given to everyone among God's people, regardless of gender, age, or social status. This fulfilled what Moses wanted, that every Israelite might be a prophet (Numbers 11:29), allowing all to prophesy and see visions.

In Acts 2:1–47, Peter expanded this promise to include people from all over the known world who were gathered in Jerusalem, regardless of their ethnicity (Acts 2:39; see also Galatians 3:28).

Joel 2:28–32

The prophet envisioned a future day of the Lord. On this day, God would share his Spirit in new ways and show signs and wonders for everyone to witness. The apostle Peter said this prophecy came true on the day of Pentecost (Acts 2:16–21).

Joel 2:28–3.21

In the distant future, God will restore his people's spiritual lives. He will give his Spirit to all who respond to him with faith. He will judge the peoples and nations that refuse to recognize his authority.

Joel 2:30–31

When God pours out his Spirit in the future, there will be signs and wonders. Blood, fire, and smoke, along with the darkening of the sun and moon, will show God's coming judgment (see Joel 2:10; Mark 13:24; Revelation 6:12).

Joel 2:32

- everyone who calls on the name of the LORD will be saved: Calling on God's name should not be a final act of desperation. It should be part of a lifelong commitment to worship, serve, and have fellowship with the Lord (see Genesis 12:8; Psalm 105:1; Isaiah 12:4; Romans 10:13; 12:1–2).
- Those whom the Lord has called are his chosen remnant. They are the survivors of judgment who worship him (see 2 Kings 19:31; Ezra 9:8–15; Isaiah 10:20–22).

Joel 3:1–16

Here, Joel spoke about God's coming judgment on the nations, especially those that had oppressed God's people.

Joel 3:2–3

- The Lord would gather the armies of the world (literally all the nations) in the valley of Jehoshaphat. This valley is not related to King Jehoshaphat of Judah (1 Kings 22:41). Instead, it means "the valley where the Lord judges." It is the place where God would decide the fate of the nations (see Joel 3:14).
- The sins of the nations included driving God's covenant people into exile. They also included abusing helpless boys and girls by selling them as slaves (compare Ezekiel 27:13; Revelation 18:13).

Joel 3:4–6

The Phoenician cities of Tyre and Sidon, along with the cities of Philistia, were guilty of stealing valuable treasures from Jerusalem. They also sold the people of Jerusalem as slaves to the Greeks (see Amos 1:6, 9).

Joel 3:7–8

The people of Tyre, Sidon, and Philistia had enslaved Israelites, so the Lord would punish them by selling their sons and daughters into slavery.

Joel 3:9

The nations are called to fight against the Lord, but the call is meant to show how useless their war would be. Their rebellion would end in destruction and judgment.

Joel 3:10

Beat your plowshares into swords: This command deliberately reverses the picture of peace found in Isaiah 2:4 and Micah 4:3. Instead of laying down weapons, the nations were told to prepare for war.

Joel ordered them to gather every possible resource for the coming battle. Even those who were weak and not fit for war were told to become soldiers.

Joel 3:12

The battle will occur in the valley of Jehoshaphat (see study note on Joel 3:2–3), where the Lord will judge everyone.

Joel 3:13

God would defeat the nations completely. He would judge them like a sickle that cuts down grain at harvest time. He would also judge them like workers who crush grapes in a winepress until nothing remains (see Isaiah 63:2–3; Revelation 14:14–20).

Joel 3:14

- Multitudes, multitudes: The repetition of the Hebrew word captures the chaotic noise made by a huge crowd.
- valley of decision: The name of the valley is changed because the Lord has now decided to judge the nations (see Joel 3:2–3, 12).

Joel 3:16

The Lord's voice would sound like the roar of a lion. It would come from Zion and shake heaven and earth. This roar would terrify those who oppose God (see Amos 1:2). Yet the same Lord, strong like a lion, would also be a place of safety for his people.

Joel 3:17

Then you will know: God's ultimate purpose is for his people to know him and to share in his holy character. They must learn that he is the only God and that he rules over all creation from Zion, his holy mountain (see also Joel 2:27). True security now and hope for the future come from God's presence.

Joel 3:18

Blessings will come from the Lord's powerful presence in Zion (see also Ezekiel 47:1–12; Amos 9:13). There will be an abundance of sweet wine and milk. The temple, God's dwelling on earth, will be the source of a spring that will always water the dry land (see Zechariah 14:8; Revelation 22:1–2).

Joel 3:19

Even as Judah is restored, her ancient enemies Egypt and Edom would face God's judgment for the harm they had done to his people.

Joel 3:20–21

The end of Joel's prophecy is the opposite of its beginning. In Joel 1:1–20, Judah's future seemed uncertain. Plague and drought, signs of divine judgment, threatened Judah's survival. Now Joel concludes with the divine promise that Judah and Jerusalem will last through all generations. God's people in every era find security in the hope that his kingdom will rule over heaven and earth (see also Isaiah 9:6–7; Daniel 2:44; 7:13–14).